



ABBOTSLEIGH

STUDENT NUMBER

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2025 HSC TRIAL EXAMINATION

English Extension 1

Section I and Section II

General Instructions

- Reading time – 10 minutes
- Working time – 2 hours
- Write using black pen
- Write your student number as indicated

Total marks: 50

Section I: Literary Worlds (25 marks)

Attempt Question 1

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Section II: Electives (25 marks)

Attempt one question from Questions 2(a) – 2(e)

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Section I — Common Module: Literary Worlds

25 marks

Attempt Question 1

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Your answers will be assessed on how well you:

- demonstrate an understanding of the ideas and values of Literary Worlds and how they are shaped and reflected in texts
 - craft a sustained composition appropriate to the question, demonstrating control of the use of language
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Read Text 1 and Text 2

Question 1 (25 marks)

(a) Use Text 1 and Text 2 to answer this question.

10

“In literary worlds, the relationship between memory, identity and place is often shaped by the blurring of boundaries between the personal and the public.”

Critically evaluate this statement with close reference to the extract adapted from Chapter 1 of Isabel Allende’s *The House of the Spirits* and the accompanying article ‘At the Threshold of Memory: Isabel Allende’s World-Building in *The House of the Spirits*’. In your response, you should also draw on your broader knowledge and understanding of the module *Literary Worlds*.

(b) Imaginative Composition

15

“The past is never gone—it lingers in places, in people, and in the stories we choose to tell.”

Craft an imaginative moment that explores the entanglement of memory and history within a private or public world.

In your response, demonstrate an understanding of Literary Worlds.

Question 1 continues on the next page

Text 1 – Novel Extract: Adapted from Chapter 1 of *The House of the Spirits* by Isabel Allende

Barrabás came to us by sea, the child Clara wrote in her delicate calligraphy. She was already in the habit of writing down important matters, and afterward, when she was mute, she also recorded trivialities, never suspecting that fifty years later I would use her notebooks to reclaim the past and overcome terrors of my own. Barrabás arrived on a Holy Thursday. It was a bland, autumnal day that gave no hint of the events that the child would record, which took place during the noon mass in the parish of San Sebastián. As a sign of mourning, the statues of the saints were shrouded in purple robes. Beneath these funereal sheets the celestial retinue¹ resembled nothing so much as a roomful of furniture awaiting movers, an impression that the candles, the incense, and the soft moans of the organ were powerless to counteract.

The only one whose appearance was enhanced by mourning was the church's patron saint, Sebastián, for during Holy Week the faithful were spared the sight of that body twisted in the most indecent posture, pierced by arrows, and dripping with blood and tears like a suffering homosexual, whose wounds, kept miraculously fresh by Father Restrepo's brush, made Clara tremble with disgust.

Severo del Valle was an atheist and a Mason, but he had political ambitions and could not allow himself the luxury of missing mass on feast days, when everyone would have a chance to see him. His wife, Nívea, preferred to deal with God without benefit of intermediaries. She had a deep distrust of cassocks² and was bored by descriptions of heaven, purgatory and hell, but she shared her husband's parliamentary ambitions, hoping that if he won a seat in Congress she would finally secure the vote for women. Clara, the youngest of her children, was seated beside her mother, who squeezed her hand impatiently whenever the priest lingered too long on the sins of the flesh, for she knew that this would only lead the child to visualise with even greater accuracy aberrations³ that transcended reality.

Just at that moment, as Nívea would recall years later, in the midst of all that anxiety and silence, the voice of little Clara was heard in all its purity.

"Psst! Father Restrepo! If that story about hell is a lie, we're all fucked, aren't we...?"

The Jesuit's index finger, which was already raised to illustrate additional tortures, remained suspended like a lightning rod above his head. People stopped breathing. Señor and Señora del Valle reacted first. Severo grabbed his wife by the arm and Clara by the neck and walked out, followed by the rest of the children, who stampeded toward the door.

By Isabel Allende

¹ Retinue: a group of people who accompany and support an important person, often in a formal or ceremonial context. This group may include assistants, advisers, attendants, or followers.

² Cassocks: a long, close-fitting, ankle-length robe worn by members of the clergy or other church officials, often as part of their official or ceremonial dress.

³ Aberrations: something that deviates from what is normal, expected, or accepted — often in a way that is unusual, strange, or unsettling.

Text 2 – Critical Extract: ‘At the Threshold of Memory: Isabel Allende’s World-Building in *The House of the Spirits*’

From the opening line — “Barrabás came to us by sea” — Isabel Allende begins not just a narrative, but the shaping of a literary world steeped in memory, ritual, and quiet subversion. In the first scene of Chapter 1, this world is rendered with precision and resonance, drawing the reader into a space where the familiar is made strange, and the personal is inseparable from symbolic structures of power.

Set during a Holy Thursday mass, the church is evoked through layered sensory detail — incense, candlelight, silence, and purple-shrouded saints. The space appears sacred, yet Allende quietly undermines its authority. Saint Sebastián is rendered grotesque, and the statues appear lifeless, “like furniture awaiting movers.” This technique recalls Mikhail Bakhtin’s concept of the carnivalesque, where dominant structures of meaning — religious, moral, political — are momentarily suspended or inverted, revealing their instability (*Rabelais and His World*, 1965). Allende’s world is thus not stable or reverent, but one in tension — a site of theatrical control and latent resistance.

Characterisation deepens this world’s complexity. Severo, a political aspirant, performs piety without belief. Nívea endures the constraints of gendered expectation, her internal monologue filled with scepticism. These figures position the reader within a social order defined by performance and contradiction. In this way, Allende enacts what Linda Hutcheon describes as the function of historiographic metafiction: the destabilisation of historical “truth” through a blending of narrative voice, irony, and personal perception (*A Poetics of Postmodernism*, 1988).

Clara, the youngest daughter, quietly occupies the centre of this world. We learn she is already recording “important matters” — an act that will later shape the novel’s structure. Clara’s narrative presence links the present scene to an act of remembering, positioning the entire fictional world as something constructed through retrospection. As Elizabeth Waites notes, Clara “mediates the novel’s sense of time, making the personal past continuous and accessible” (*Latin American Women Writers*, 1996). The act of remembering becomes a mode of world-building — a way of recovering and reshaping experience through written reflection.

At the chapter’s climax, Clara’s question — “If that story about hell is a lie, we’re all fucked, aren’t we...?” — ruptures the world’s ceremonial order. Her child’s voice deflates ecclesiastical authority, disarming not only Father Restrepo, but the entire congregation. This moment aligns with Wolfgang Iser’s theory of “blanks” in the text: moments where narrative structure opens itself to reader interpretation, disrupting expectation and provoking

reflection (*The Act of Reading*, 1978). Through Clara, the text inserts an interpretive void — a moment of irreverence that reconfigures the reader’s understanding of the moral and ideological framework previously established.

Tzvetan Todorov has argued that the fantastic emerges in literature where uncertainty between the real and the unreal is sustained (*The Fantastic*, 1973). Allende’s world hovers in this ambiguity — grounded in sensory realism but edged with the spectral, shaped as much by perception and memory as by action.

In just one scene, Allende constructs a world where ritual is strained, language resists closure, and voice becomes a mode of rebellion. This is a world born from memory, but one in which meaning is continually negotiated — by characters, by readers, and by the act of storytelling itself.

By A. S. Calderón

End of Section I

SECTION II: Electives

25 marks

Attempt ONE question from Question 2(a) – 2(e)

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Read the question carefully and then answer the question on the lined writing paper provided.

Your answers will be assessed on how well you:

- demonstrate an understanding of the ideas and values of your elective and how they are shaped and reflected in texts
 - craft a sustained composition appropriate to the question, demonstrating control of the use of language
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Question 2(a) — Elective 1: Literary Homelands (25 marks)

“Fiction reveals truth that reality obscures.” — Ralph Waldo Emerson

Evaluate this statement with reference to how literary texts invite responders to engage with the reality of home. In your response, analyse how composers represent thought, feeling and perception to explore representation of Literary Homelands.

Support your discussion with detailed reference to TWO prescribed texts and ONE related text of your own choosing.

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction**
 - Aravind Adiga, *The White Tiger*
 - E M Forster, *A Passage to India*
 - Colm Tóibín, *Brooklyn*
- **Poetry**
 - Eileen Chong, *Burning Rice*
 - * *Burning Rice*
 - * *Mid-autumn Mooncakes*
 - * *My Hakka Grandmother*
 - * *Shophouse, Victoria Street*
 - * *Chinese Ginseng*
 - * *Winter Meeting*
 - * *Singapore*
- **Drama**
 - Andrew Bovell, *The Secret River*
- **Film**
 - Sarah Gavron, *Brick Lane*

Question 2(b) — Elective 2: Worlds of Upheaval (25 marks)

“Fiction reveals truth that reality obscures.” — Ralph Waldo Emerson

Evaluate this statement with reference to how literary texts invite responders to engage with personal and public upheaval. In your response, analyse how composers represent thought, feeling and perception to explore Worlds of Upheaval.

Support your discussion with detailed reference to TWO prescribed texts and ONE related text of your own choosing.

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction** – Elizabeth Gaskell, *North and South*
 - Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein*
 - Madeleine Thien, *Do Not Say We Have Nothing*
- **Poetry** – Seamus Heaney, *Opened Ground: Poems 1966–1996*

The prescribed poems are:

- * *Digging*
- * *The Strand at Lough Beg*
- * *Casualty*
- * *Funeral Rites*
- * from *Whatever You Say Say Nothing*
- * *Triptych*

- **Drama** – Samuel Beckett, *Waiting for Godot*
- **Film** – Fritz Lang, *Metropolis*

Question 2(e) — Elective 5: Intersecting Worlds (25 marks)

“Fiction reveals truth that reality obscures.” — Ralph Waldo Emerson

Evaluate this statement with reference to how literary texts invite responders to consider the tension between nature and human activity. In your response, analyse how composers represent thought, feeling and perception to explore Intersecting Worlds.

Support your discussion with detailed reference to TWO prescribed texts and ONE related text of your own choosing.

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction**
 - Melissa Harrison, *Clay*
 - Alex Miller, *Journey to the Stone Country*
 - Annie Proulx, *The Shipping News*
- **Nonfiction**
 - Tim Winton, *Island Home*
- **Poetry**
 - William Wordsworth, *William Wordsworth: The Major Works*

The prescribed poems are:

- * *Lines written a few miles above Tintern Abbey*
- * *Three years she grew in sun and shower*
- * *My heart leaps up when I behold*
- * *Resolution and Independence*
- * *The world is too much with us*
- * *Ode (‘There was a time’)*
- * *The Solitary Reaper*
- * *The Prelude* (1805) – Book One, lines 1–67, 271– 441

- **Film**
 - Daniel Nettheim, *The Hunter*

End of paper